

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 76

Culture (OWC): [Azande \(F007\)](#)

Region: Africa

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Place Coverage

Sudan and Democratic Republic of the Congo

Section Title(S): BLOOD-BROTHERHOOD • DEATH

Today the most important duties laid on blood-brothers are to assist a man's affines to dig his grave, and to contribute to the mortuary feast. If a man has to raise compensation for witchcraft, homicide, or adultery, a blood-brother must assist him; in the old days, when a man stood in danger of instant mutilation for the last offence, this help had to be immediate. Other duties, which have now largely lost their importance, were to warn the other if he had incurred the chief's displeasure, and to assist at the post-mortem on a dead brother's corpse, or the corpse of a kinsman of his. ⁵⁷ There are occasional instances of one blood-brother being treacherous to another, usually by committing adultery with his wife, but such breaches are rare.

[608
Artificial Kin
Relationships](#)

The behaviour which blood-brothers are expected to assume towards each other is the opposite of that required towards kin and in-laws, and they stand to each other in a sort of **joking** relationship. They abuse each other with impunity, saying things that would normally be considered causes of deep quarrels. In a modified form this **joking** relationship is extended to clansmen, known as *bakulemi*; and between certain clans, such as the Abanvra, Abangombi, Akalinga, and Agiti, a permanent **joking** relationship has grown up. ⁵⁸

[608
Artificial Kin
Relationships](#)

Avungara seldom exchange blood, for they are all of one clan and therefore should already be prepared to assist each other; occasionally, however, they may make a pact and are not forbidden to do so within the clan, as commoners are. Neither do they normally exchange blood with commoners, for that would be to disparage themselves. Further, a Vungara stands for authority and justice while one of the purposes of blood-brotherhood is to evade legal obligations and the chief's displeasure. They did, however, at times, use it as a political measure and to facilitate the subjugation of conquered peoples.

608
Artificial Kin
Relationships

614
Clans

The pact now appears to be degenerating into a sort of formal confirmation of friendship between two individuals, for many of the social situations which formerly made the bond so useful have ceased to exist.

608
Artificial Kin
Relationships

DEATH

All serious illness and all deaths are believed by the Azande to be due to witchcraft,⁵⁹ and it is incumbent on the kin of the sufferer to search out the witch and endeavour to divert or put an end to his activity; if they fail in this, they must obtain compensation or avenge the murder. A sick man, or one who is threatened by witchcraft, will borrow poison (*benge*) from a near kinsman, such as a brother, or a close affine, such as his father-in-law (if he does not possess a stock of his own), and consult the poison oracle. If he is too sick to consult the oracle himself, he will get someone to perform this service for him. Near kinsmen and near affines are equally responsible.⁶⁰ Correspondingly, a man accused of witchcraft depends on the backing of his kin, in-laws, and blood-brothers to assist him in paying any compensation awarded against him.

683
Offenses Against The
Person

754
Sorcery

761
Life And Death

The family of a dead man or woman announce the death at once by their mourning cries and by beating the mourning gong, and then immediately prepare the corpse for burial. The bark-cloth is removed, the body is washed and anointed with oil, then swathed in a wrapper of bush straw, and laid on a sort of stretcher (*kitik pala*) in the hut where death occurred. When a married person dies, the 77 partner is stripped by the dead person's kin, and spends the night naked by the side of the corpse, abstaining from food, drink, sleep, and speech until it is buried. The brothers and sisters of the mourner may do the same.

764
Burial Practices And
Funerals

57 Evans-Pritchard, op. cit., pp. 388-9.

58 Ibid., p. 392.

59 See below, p. 80.

60 See Evans-Pritchard, 24, 1937, pp. 90-2.

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